

# 1–3 Union Square West

## Stone Threshold at the Square's Edge: A Narrative Deep Dive into 1–3 Union Square West

Every previously italicized phrase is highlighted and colour-coded by source. Where the source page is on file, clicking the highlight opens the scan.

**COLOUR KEY — ONE COLOUR PER SOURCE** · sources with a page scan are marked ↗

|                                                                               |                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ■ Stern, <i>New York</i> 1880, 1999 p. 442 (2) ↗                              | ■ Sackersdorff, <i>1815 Blue Book</i> p. 3 (1) ↗                               |
| ■ Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016 p. 346 (9) ↗            | ■ Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009 p. 76 (2) ↗ |
| ■ LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890 p. 1 (39) ↗                                 | ■ AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988 p. 186 (1) ↗                                |
| ■ Wolfe, <i>New York 15 Walking Tours</i> , 2003 p. 251 (1) ↗                 | ■ Bromley, <i>1897 Bromleys Atlas</i> p. 19 (1) ↗                              |
| ■ G W Bromley & Co, <i>1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan</i> p. 54 (1) ↗ | ■ Bromley, <i>1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan</i> p. 53 (1) ↗       |
| ■ Bromley, <i>1955 Manhattan Land Book</i> p. 43 (1) ↗                        | ■ Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020 p. 97 (2) ↗                         |
| ■ Stern, <i>New York</i> 2000, 2006 p. 377 (1) ↗                              |                                                                                |

**AUDIO — 1–3 UNION SQUARE WEST | BRICK CAKE** 14 min 50 s

Audio track — playable in the HTML version of this document.

### PREFACE

At the acute northwest corner where East Fourteenth Street meets Union Square West stands a commercial pile of profound art-historical consequence, valued not merely for its ornamental exuberance but for its status as a hinge-point in the evolution of the American tall building. The documentary record fixes its authorship and its moment with clarity, for it is remembered as *(R. H. Robertson's Lincoln Building (1885), at the northwest corner of Fourteenth Street and Broadway (Union Square West), was as substantial as any office building downtown.)* It is, in the fullest sense, a chrysalis specimen caught mid-metamorphosis between the age of the load-bearing masonry wall and the age of the fully articulated steel cage.

### I. FROM EMPTY ANGLE TO CORNER MONUMENT

The site was not always so consequential. Its earliest record is one of pure absence, for *(In the 1815 Blue Book, on 1 Union Square West, there is reference to 0 structures.)* The ground itself was a creature of the city's geometry, since *(When the Commissioners Map of 1807-11 first laid out Manhattan's grid plan, the acute angle where Bloomingdale Road (now Broadway) intersected the bowery at 16th Street demarcated an island*

of land that was dubbed Union Place.) What began as marginal terrain was steadily reclaimed, for (Initially, the poor built shanties there, but by 1839, Union Square (as it came to be known) had been graded, paved, and fenced in, and it was set aside for military and civic parades and festivities), until at last (By the 1850s, mansions had sprung up around the picturesque square.) The corner would eventually surrender its domestic character to the vertical ambitions of the age, since (Within a few decades, tall commercial buildings, like the nine-story Lincoln, replaced the mansions as the city grew northward.)

## II. STRUCTURAL SYSTEM AND THE QUESTION OF THE SKYSCRAPER

The building embodies a hybrid tectonic condition in which an interior armature of metal operates in concert with, rather than in place of, its perimeter walls, for (Combining metal-skeleton interior construction with masonry-bearing walls, the Lincoln represents a transitional phase in skyscraper construction.) The threshold it approaches but does not cross is a precise one, since (The essential criterion of a true skyscraper is the replacement of load-bearing walls with a steel skeleton that provides all of the structural support.) The Lincoln Building has not yet attained that emancipation; its walls remain palpably tectonic and their gravitational labor unconcealed, for (In the Lincoln Building, Romanesque Revival arcades articulate the skeletal construction, although the massiveness of the walls is evident, and the horizontality of traditional masonry is further emphasized by the stacked fenestration.) The eye is thus drawn along the width rather than propelled up the height—a signature of the pre-steel sensibility. The engineering historians confirm the same reading, for (The budding, faced in limestone, granite, redbrick, and terra cotta, marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering; it was constructed with a metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls.)

## III. COMPOSITIONAL GOVERNANCE AND THE TRIPARTITE TYPOLOGY

The elevation is disciplined according to the (Tripartite Typology)—base, shaft, and capital transposed onto the commercial block and read as analogous to the column. Yet Robertson's handling drew contemporary censure for its want of hierarchical clarity, since it was judged (A not-quite-resolved essay in the Romanesque, with many layers of motifs rather than a dominant arcade, Robertson's first tall building was said to possess, according to the Record and Guide, "a wandering, hesitating air about it as though the architect could not hit upon the right word for his idea and took refuge in redundancy.) This redundancy is, to the modern eye, precisely the source of the building's dense textural richness—a palimpsest of (Layered Arcades) rather than a single triumphal arch-motif.

#### IV. CLADDING AND MATERIAL PALETTE

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The material vocabulary is a deliberately variegated masonry ensemble, for the building is *(Sheathed in Indiana limestone, granite, and brick, the building is ornamented with exceptional details: acanthus scrolls, Byzantine capitals, griffins, and human and lion heads, all carved in terra cotta.)* The governing idiom throughout is *(Romanesque-Revival)*, and the chromatic register moves from a warm, earthen base value—recorded as *(Tumbleweed - 222 166 131)*—rising toward a pale, luminous crown recorded as *(Pearl White - 238 235 218)*, an atmospheric perspective built into the very substance of the wall. The base is executed in *(Indiana Limestone)* and grounded upon *(Granite Bulkheads)*, the granite reserved for those thresholds where abrasion demands the hardest igneous stone; the upper envelope continues in *(Indiana Limestone)* supplemented by *(Terra Cotta)* and *(Light Brick)*. A critical subtlety of surface is the deliberate juxtaposition described as *(Smooth and Rock Faced Indiana Limestone)*—the rusticated ashlar delivering the quarried gravitas of the Romanesque, the smooth stone furnishing the refined foil against which carved ornament registers with crispness.

#### V. THE ENTRANCE PORTAL

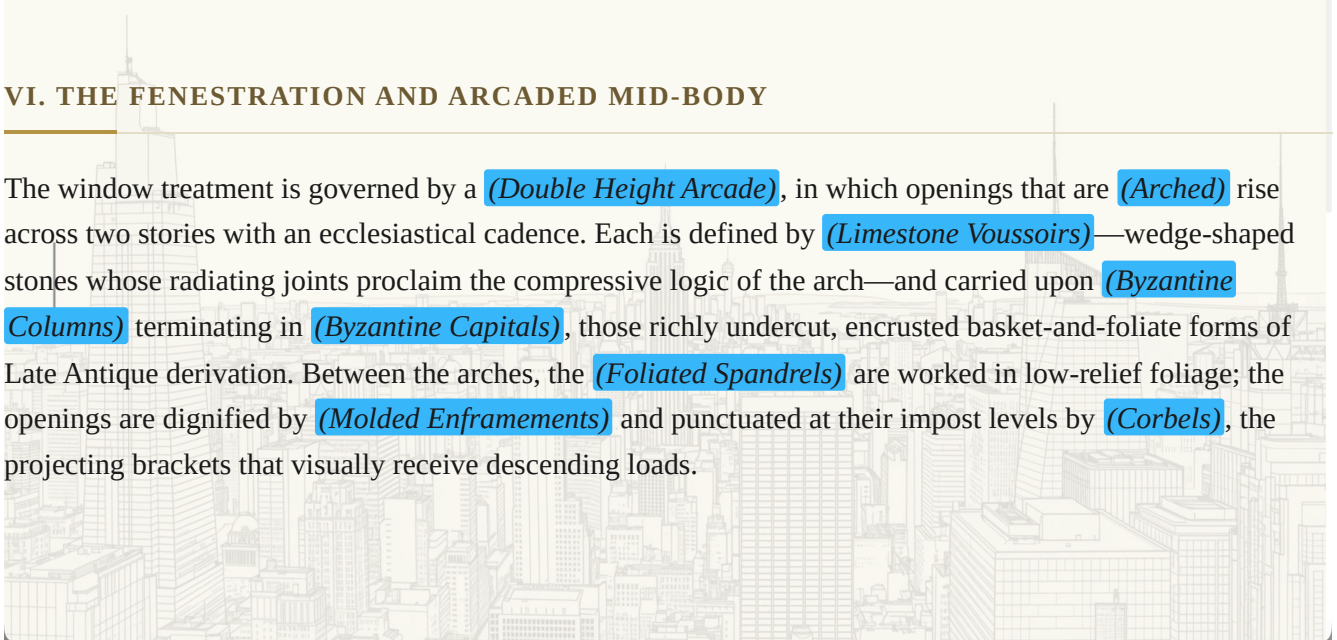
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The principal entrance is a *(4 Bays)* arrangement dominated by a deeply modeled *(Round Arch)*—the semicircular arch that is the very grammar of the revival—springing from *(Engaged Columns)* embedded in the wall plane. The archivolt marries two contrasting idioms: the classical, vegetal *(Acanthus Scrolls)* with their fleshy, involuted leaf-forms, set in pointed counterpoint against the jagged, medieval chevron of the *(Norman Zigzag Molding)*. The coexistence of these vocabularies—one botanical and antique, one geometric and Anglo-Norman—epitomizes the eclectic layering of the whole.

#### VI. THE FENESTRATION AND ARCADED MID-BODY

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The window treatment is governed by a *(Double Height Arcade)*, in which openings that are *(Arched)* rise across two stories with an ecclesiastical cadence. Each is defined by *(Limestone Voussoirs)*—wedge-shaped stones whose radiating joints proclaim the compressive logic of the arch—and carried upon *(Byzantine Columns)* terminating in *(Byzantine Capitals)*, those richly undercut, encrusted basket-and-foliage forms of Late Antique derivation. Between the arches, the *(Foliated Spandrels)* are worked in low-relief foliage; the openings are dignified by *(Molded Enframements)* and punctuated at their impost levels by *(Corbels)*, the projecting brackets that visually receive descending loads.



## VII. THE FIGURATIVE AND SCULPTURAL PROGRAM

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A menagerie of ornament of exceptional refinement is dispersed across pier, spandrel, and cornice. Chief among the figural motifs is the *(Griffin)*—the composite beast pressed here into commercial heraldry—marching alongside bands of *(Acanthus Scrolls)* and clusters of *(Byzantine Capitals)* set upon the *(Limestone Piers)* that establish the vertical armature. Most arresting is the population of *(Human Heads)* and *(Lion Heads)*, anthropomorphic and leonine masks peering from the wall in the tradition of the medieval label-stop and corbel-head, performing at once the office of ornamental delight and of structural expression.

## VIII. THE ROOFLINE AND TERMINATING CORNICE: THE CROWN

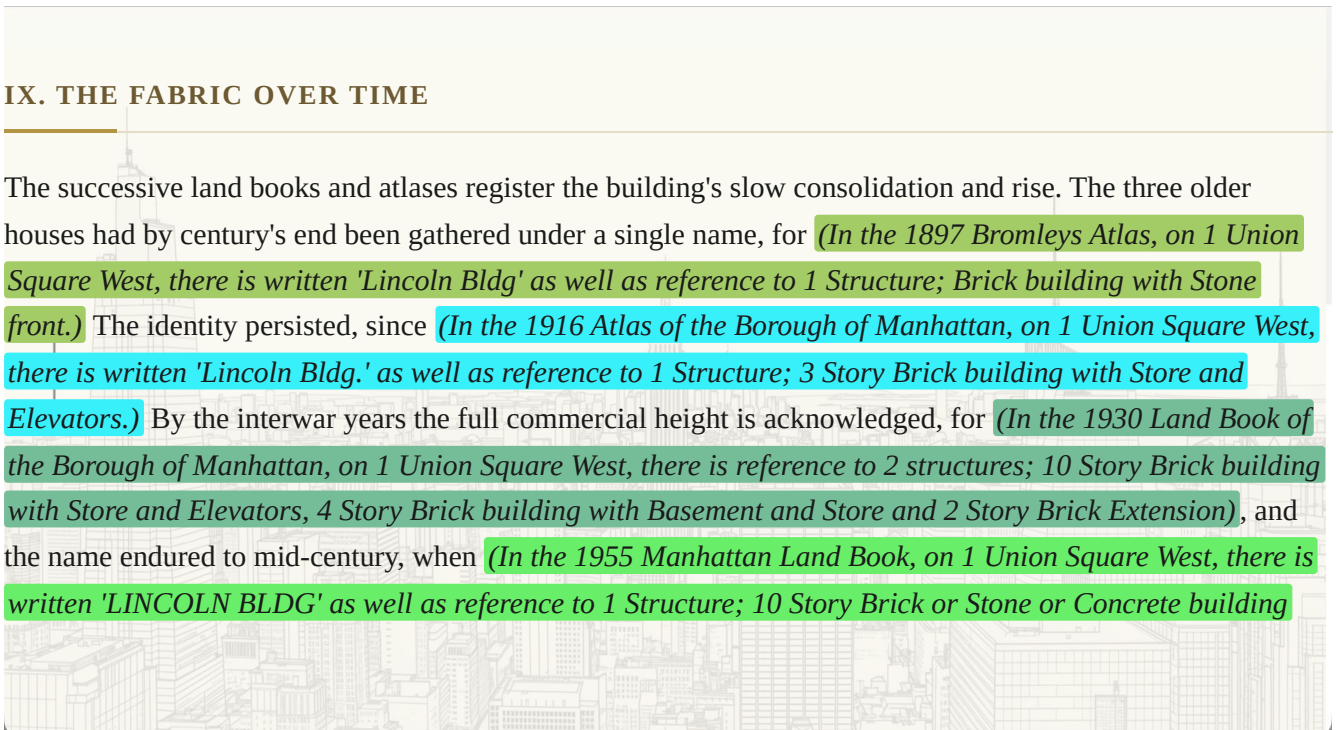
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The composition terminates in a boldly *(Projecting Cornice)*, cantilevered from the wall plane to cast a deep shadow against the sky. Its most celebrated feature is an extraordinary fenestrated frieze, described from the street as *(Romanesque Revival granite crowned with a cornice of 40 little windows with interstitial paired columns)*—a quasi-loggia effect reminiscent of the dwarf galleries ringing Lombard-Romanesque apses, and a member so memorable that the visitor is urged simply to *(Note the multiwindow cornice.)* Enriching this crown is a cascade of further ornament: a *(Band of Bosses)*, the load-receiving *(Human/Lion Corbels)*, the interlaced ribbon of the *(Byzantine Guilloche)*, colonnettes twisted into helical couplets as *(Paired Spiral Columns)*, a course of *(Dentils)*, shadow-catching *(Recessed Panels)*, the convex quarter-round of the *(Ovolo Molding)*, and, crowning all, an *(Acanthus Scroll Band)* that returns at the summit to the vegetal theme announced below at the entrance arch.

## IX. THE FABRIC OVER TIME

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The successive land books and atlases register the building's slow consolidation and rise. The three older houses had by century's end been gathered under a single name, for *(In the 1897 Bromleys Atlas, on 1 Union Square West, there is written 'Lincoln Bldg' as well as reference to 1 Structure; Brick building with Stone front.)* The identity persisted, since *(In the 1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan, on 1 Union Square West, there is written 'Lincoln Bldg.' as well as reference to 1 Structure; 3 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators.)* By the interwar years the full commercial height is acknowledged, for *(In the 1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan, on 1 Union Square West, there is reference to 2 structures; 10 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators, 4 Story Brick building with Basement and Store and 2 Story Brick Extension),* and the name endured to mid-century, when *(In the 1955 Manhattan Land Book, on 1 Union Square West, there is written 'LINCOLN BLDG' as well as reference to 1 Structure; 10 Story Brick or Stone or Concrete building*



*with Store and Elevators.*) More than a century after its completion, the fabric was addressed anew, for *(In late 2015, plans were approved by the NYC Department of Buildings for facade repairs and roof replacement)*—the two interventions most vital to a masonry envelope of this age and ornamental density.

## X. RELATIONSHIP TO NEIGHBOR AND STREETScape

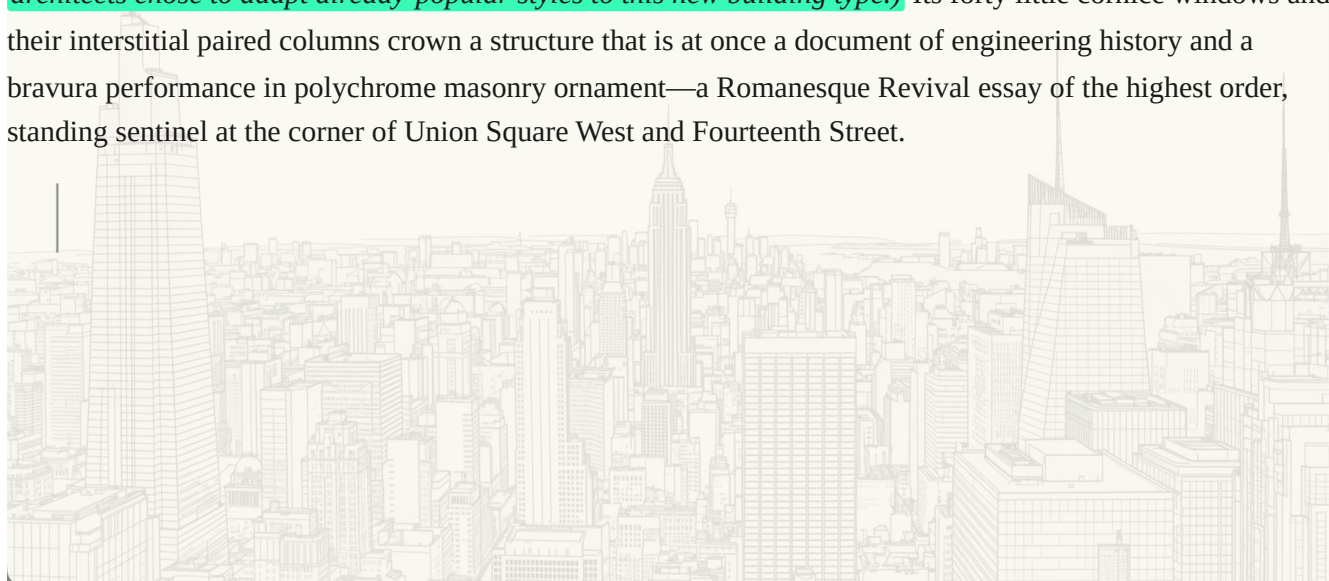
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The building participates in a dialogue of façades along the west flank of the square. Its principal interlocutor is the structure immediately to its north, for *(The block between 14th and 15th Streets offers two solid and accomplished historic structures: the Spingler Building (5 Union Square West 1897. W H. Hume and Sons) and the Lincoln Building (1 Union Square West, 1889. R. H. Robertson).)* The two are close kin yet part company in dialect, since *(The two facades share many compositional details, but one architect has chosen a classical vocabulary while the other has embraced the Romanesque.)* Its recognition as a monument came not through unprompted reverence but through anxiety over the district's future, for *(Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1-3 Union Square West; the Bank of the Metropolis (Bruce Price, 1903), 31 Union Square West; the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street; the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street; and the Germania Life Insurance Company Building (D'Oench & Yost, 1911), later the Guardian Life Building, 50 Union Square East.)*

## XI. CODA

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The building is, in sum, a masterwork of the transitional moment, and it endures within the canon precisely because *(The Lincoln Building is representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York, where architects chose to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type.)* Its forty little cornice windows and their interstitial paired columns crown a structure that is at once a document of engineering history and a bravura performance in polychrome masonry ornament—a Romanesque Revival essay of the highest order, standing sentinel at the corner of Union Square West and Fourteenth Street.



## CITATION CHART

Every highlighted quote, in order of appearance, correlated to its underlying source. The swatch matches the highlight colour in the text.

| #  | Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)                                                                                                                                                   | Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)                                                                                                                                       |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | "R. H. Robertson's Lincoln Building (1885), at the northwest corner of Fourteenth Street and Broadway (Union Square West), was as substantial as any office building..."       |  Stern, <i>New York 1880</i> , 1999, p. 442 [page scan]                                |
| 2  | "In the 1815 Blue Book, on 1 Union Square West, there is reference to 0 structures."                                                                                           |  Sackersdorff, <i>1815 Blue Book</i> , p. 3 [page scan]                                |
| 3  | "When the Commissioners Map of 1807-11 first laid out Manhattan's grid plan, the acute angle where Bloomingdale Road (now Broadway) intersected the bowery at 16th Street..."  |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]               |
| 4  | "Initially, the poor built shanties there, but by 1839, Union Square (as it came to be known) had been graded, paved, and fenced in, and it was set aside for military and..." |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]               |
| 5  | "By the 1850s, mansions had sprung up around the picturesque square."                                                                                                          |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]             |
| 6  | "Within a few decades, tall commercial buildings, like the nine-story Lincoln, replaced the mansions as the city grew northward."                                              |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]             |
| 7  | "Combining metal-skeleton interior construction with masonry-bearing walls, the Lincoln represents a transitional phase in skyscraper construction."                           |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]             |
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| 9  | "In the Lincoln Building, Romanesque Revival arcades articulate the skeletal construction, although the massiveness of the walls is evident, and the horizontality of..."      |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]             |
| 10 | "The budding, faced in limestone, granite, redbrick, and terra cotta, marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering; it was constructed with a metal..."     |  Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009, p. 76 [page scan] |
| 11 | "Tripartite Typology"                                                                                                                                                          |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                   |
| 12 | "A not-quite-resolved essay in the Romanesque, with many layers of motifs rather than a dominant arcade, Robertson's first tall building was said to possess, according to..." |  Stern, <i>New York 1880</i> , 1999, p. 442 [page scan]                              |
| 13 | "Layered Arcades"                                                                                                                                                              |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                   |
| 14 | "Sheathed in Indiana limestone, granite, and brick, the building is ornamented with exceptional details: acanthus scrolls, Byzantine capitals, griffins, and human and..."     |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]             |

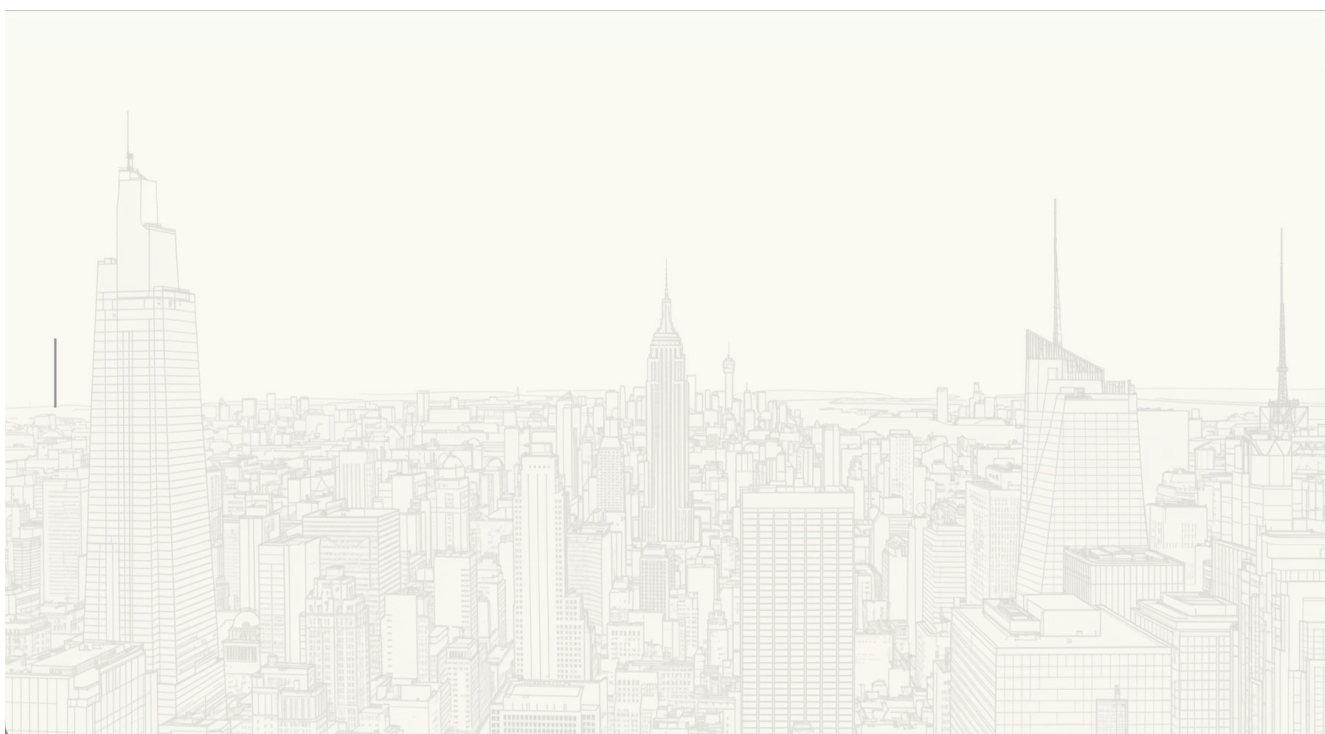
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|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 15 | "Romanesque-Revival"                                                                                      |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 16 | "Tumbleweed - 222 166 131"                                                                                |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 17 | "Pearl White - 238 235 218"                                                                               |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 18 | "Indiana Limestone"                                                                                       |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 19 | "Granite Bulkheads"                                                                                       |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 20 | "Indiana Limestone"                                                                                       |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 21 | "Terra Cotta"                                                                                             |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 22 | "Light Brick"                                                                                             |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 23 | "Smooth and Rock Faced Indiana Limestone"                                                                 |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 24 | "4 Bays"                                                                                                  |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 25 | "Round Arch"                                                                                              |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 26 | "Engaged Columns"                                                                                         |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 27 | "Acanthus Scrolls"                                                                                        |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 28 | "Norman Zigzag Molding"                                                                                   |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                    |
| 29 | "Double Height Arcade"                                                                                    |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 30 | "Arched"                                                                                                  |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 31 | "Limestone Voussoirs"                                                                                     |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 32 | "Byzantine Columns"                                                                                       |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 33 | "Byzantine Capitals"                                                                                      |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 34 | "Foliated Spandrels"                                                                                      |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 35 | "Molded Enframements"                                                                                     |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 36 | "Corbels"                                                                                                 |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 37 | "Griffin"                                                                                                 |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 38 | "Acanthus Scrolls"                                                                                        |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 39 | "Byzantine Capitals"                                                                                      |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 40 | "Limestone Piers"                                                                                         |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 41 | "Human Heads"                                                                                             |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 42 | "Lion Heads"                                                                                              |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 43 | "Projecting Cornice"                                                                                      |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                  |
| 44 | "Romanesque Revival granite crowned with a cornice of 40 little windows with interstitial paired columns" |  AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988, p. 186 [page scan]               |
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| 46 | "Band of Bosses"                                                                                                                                                              |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 47 | "Human/Lion Corbels"                                                                                                                                                          |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 48 | "Byzantine Guilloche"                                                                                                                                                         |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 49 | "Paired Spiral Columns"                                                                                                                                                       |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 50 | "Dentils"                                                                                                                                                                     |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 51 | "Recessed Panels"                                                                                                                                                             |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 52 | "Ovolo Molding"                                                                                                                                                               |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
| 53 | "Acanthus Scroll Band"                                                                                                                                                        |  LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]                                     |
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| 56 | "In the 1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan, on 1 Union Square West, there is reference to 2 structures; 10 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators, 4 Story..." |  Bromley, <i>1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan</i> , p. 53 [page scan]        |
| 57 | "In the 1955 Manhattan Land Book, on 1 Union Square West, there is written 'LINCOLN BLDG' as well as reference to 1 Structure; 10 Story Brick or Stone or Concrete..."        |  Bromley, <i>1955 Manhattan Land Book</i> , p. 43 [page scan]                        |
| 58 | "In late 2015, plans were approved by the NYC Department of Buildings for facade repairs and roof replacement"                                                                |  Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]             |
| 59 | "The block between 14th and 15th Streets offers two solid and accomplished historic structures: the Spingler Building (5 Union Square West 1897. W H. Hume and Sons) and..."  |  Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020, p. 97 [page scan]                         |
| 60 | "The two facades share many compositional details, but one architect has chosen a classical vocabulary while the other has embraced the Romanesque."                          |  Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020, p. 97 [page scan]                         |
| 61 | "Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1-3..."  |  Stern, <i>New York 2000</i> , 2006, p. 377 [page scan]                              |
| 62 | "The Lincoln Building is representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York, where architects chose to adapt already-popular styles to this new..."        |  Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009, p. 76 [page scan] |

## SOURCE PAGES

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13 scanned pages, one per cited source page. Each lists the highlighted quotes drawn from it.



**Stern, *New York* 1880, 1999, p. 442**

Quotes drawn from this page: 1 12





753 Broadway, southwest corner of East Eighth Street. J. Morgan Slade, 1880. View to the southwest. LAA. CU.

fact, architects seemed to have been pushed to a higher level of creativity than was typical in downtown buildings, perhaps because of the need for these new structures to fit in with a still fashionable residential neighborhood that was also home to the city's most exclusive shops. At the time of its completion, Griffith Thomas's Domestic Sewing Machine Company Building (1872-73), at the southwest corner of Broadway and Fourteenth Street, was the city's tallest, at 110 feet.<sup>188</sup> Given its prominent location in a still mostly residential area, it stood out as a monument. Thomas's design, consisting of five stories plus an inhabited mansard, was very Parisian, with its pronounced corner tower rising to a steep segmented dome. In contrast, J. Morgan Slade's five-story 753 Broadway (1880), at the southwest corner of Eighth Street, was a severely detailed three-by-five-bay brick and iron cube.<sup>189</sup> William Schickel's Century Company Building (1880-81), facing Union Square at 33 East Seventeenth Street, between Broadway and Fourth Avenue, developed as a speculative venture by the dry-goods company Arnold Constable, was principally leased by the company that gave the building its name, the publishers of the popular *Century Magazine* as well as *St. Nicholas Magazine*, which was written for children.<sup>190</sup> The Century Building was also home to



Lincoln Building, northwest corner of Broadway and East Fourteenth Street. R. H. Robertson, 1885. View to the northwest. AR. CU.

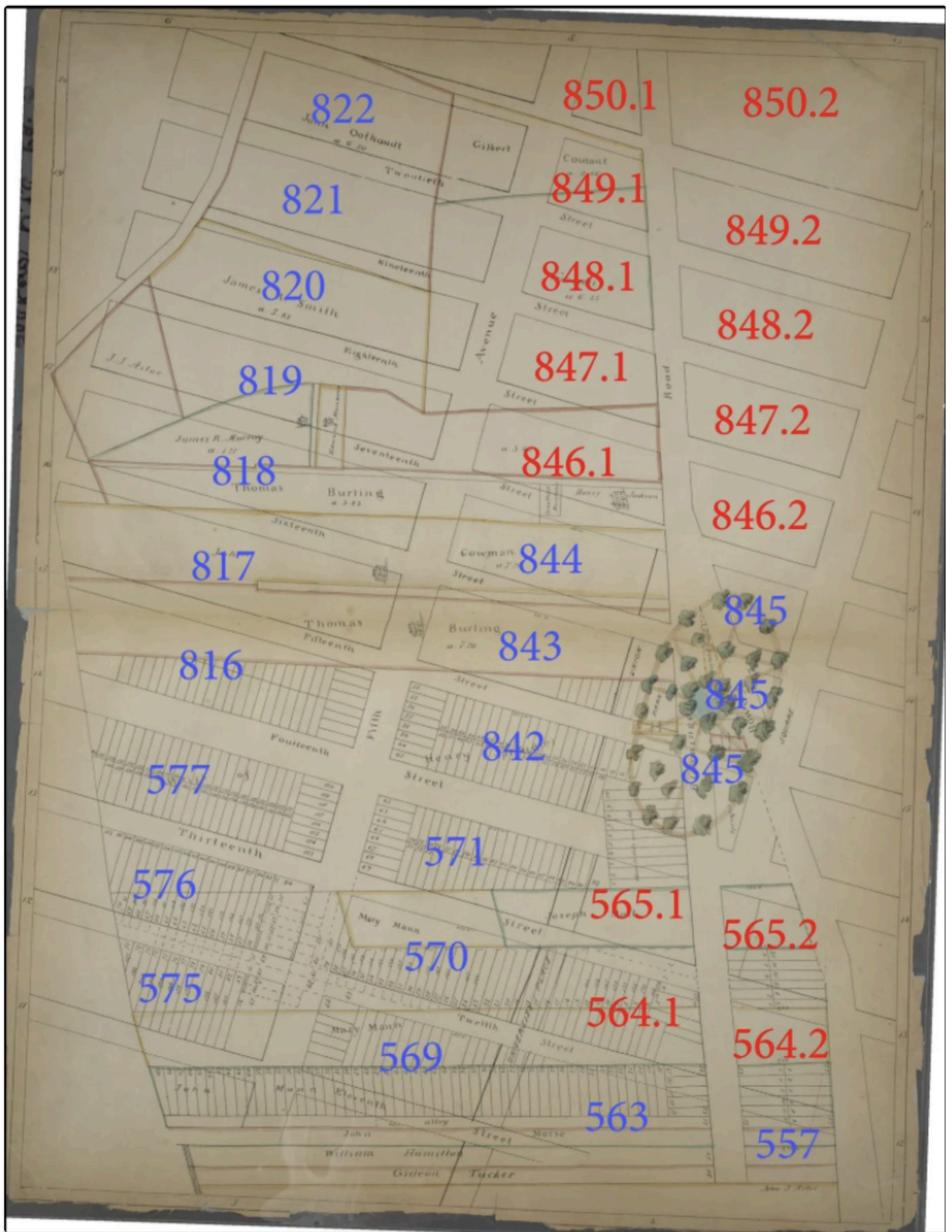


McIntyre Building, northeast corner of Broadway and East Eighteenth Street. R. H. Robertson, 1890-92. View to the northeast. King, 1893. CU.

**Sackersdorff, 1815 *Blue Book*, p. 3**

Quotes drawn from this page: 2





**Spielvogel, *The Landmarks of New York*, 2016, p. 346**

Quotes drawn from this page: 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 14 58





CHARLES A. VISSANI HOUSE

priests who lived there; it even contained a chapel. Vissani had been appointed the first Commissary General of the Holy Land for the United States in 1880. The main tasks of the Commissariat—which moved to Washington, D.C., in 1889 and is still in operation today—are to increase public awareness about the holy places of Jerusalem and to preserve and recover the sanctuaries of Palestine.

Since 1946, the property has been used as a multiunit residence, with additional units created in 1969. Nevertheless, the building's ecclesiastical overtones, heightened by pointed and ogee arches, pinnacles, trefoils, drip moldings, and lush foliated tympana, serve as an imposing reminder of its original mission.



LINCOLN BUILDING

#### LINCOLN BUILDING

1889–90; 2015–

1–3 UNION SQUARE WEST, MANHATTAN

ARCHITECT: R.H. ROBERTSON;  
RESTORATION, WALTER B. MELVIN  
ARCHITECTS

DESIGNATED: JULY 12, 1988

When the Commissioners Map of 1807–11 first laid out Manhattan's grid plan, the acute angle where Bloomingdale Road (now Broadway) intersected the Bowery at 16th Street demarcated an island of land that was dubbed Union Place. Initially, the poor built shanties there, but by 1839, Union Square (as it came to be known) had been graded, paved, and fenced in, and it was set aside for military and civic parades and festivities. By the 1850s,

mansions had sprung up around the picturesque square. Within a few decades, tall commercial buildings, like the nine-story Lincoln, replaced the mansions as the city grew northward.

Combining metal-skeleton interior construction with masonry-bearing walls, the Lincoln represents a transitional phase in skyscraper construction. The essential criterion of a true skyscraper is the replacement of load-bearing walls with a steel skeleton that provides all of the structural support. In the Lincoln Building, Romanesque Revival arcades articulate the skeletal construction, although the massiveness of the walls is evident, and the horizontality of traditional masonry is further emphasized by the stacked fenestration. Sheathed in Indiana limestone, granite, and brick, the building is ornamented with exceptional details: acanthus scrolls, Byzantine capitals, griffins, and human and lion heads, all carved in terra cotta. In late 2015, plans were approved by the NYC Department of Buildings for façade repairs and roof replacement.

#### NORWOOD NEWS, FORMERLY WILLIAMSBRIDGE RESERVOIR KEEPER'S HOUSE

1889–90; 1998

3400 RESERVOIR OVAL (ALSO KNOWN AS  
3450 PUTNAM PLACE), THE BRONX

ARCHITECT: GEORGE W. BIRDSALL,  
CHIEF ENGINEER, CROTON AQUEDUCT,  
FOR NEW YORK CITY DEPARTMENT OF  
PUBLIC WORKS

DESIGNATED: FEBRUARY 8, 2000

The Reservoir Keeper's House is the only remaining building in New York City from the Bronx and Byram Rivers



**Postal & Dolkart, *Guide to New York City Landmarks*, 2009, p. 76**

Quotes drawn from this page: 10 62



## MANHATTAN

was designed to attract the attention of riders on the Sixth Avenue Elevated, which ran in front of the building.

**195** **5, 7, 9, 17, 19, 21, and 23 West 16th Street** (c. 1845–46), designated individually 1990. In the 1840s the streets adjacent to Fifth Avenue just north of 14th Street were developed with row houses. Most of these structures were demolished as commerce invaded the area in the late 19th century, but West 16th Street retains a significant number of Greek Revival houses. The most impressive are the four survivors of a row of nine wide houses—Nos. 5, 7, 9, and 17—each of which has a full-height curving bay on its front facade, an extremely rare feature in New York. In 1930 the family-planning pioneer Margaret Sanger moved her Birth Control Clinical Research Bureau into No. 17. Nos. 19 and 21 are simpler houses displaying fine ironwork, while No. 23 has a magnificent cast-iron balcony and stoop railing. All the houses have wide stone entrance enframements with battered sides and eared corners; this is a classic Greek form copied from the window surrounds on Greek temples.

**197** **Lincoln Building, 1–3 Union Square West** (R. H. Robertson, 1889–90), designated 1988. The Lincoln Building is representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York, where architects chose to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type. Robertson designed the Lincoln Building in the same Romanesque Revival style that he used for churches, houses, and other structures. The building, faced in limestone, granite, red brick, and terra cotta, marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering: it was constructed with a metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls.

**198** **Bank of the Metropolis, 31 Union Square West** (Bruce Price, 1902–03), designated 1988. Price was an important early skyscraper designer with a particular interest in adapting the tripartite form of the column to tall buildings. This neo-Renaissance limestone-faced example is clearly massed in Price's preferred base-shaft-capital manner. The Bank of the Metropolis, founded in 1871 to serve the needs of businesses in the Union Square area, maintained its offices on the square until 1918, when it was absorbed by the Bank of Manhattan.

**199** **Decker Building, now the Union Building, 33 Union Square West** (John Edelmann in the employ of Alfred Zucker, 1892–93), designated 1988. A rare example of a Moorish-inspired skyscraper, the headquarters of the

Decker Piano Company was designed by John Edelmann, mentor and friend of Louis Sullivan. Many features of the Decker Building, most notably the naturalistic ornament, reflect Sullivan's influence. Between 1968 and 1974 Andy Warhol's Factory occupied the sixth floor. The base was handsomely restored in 1995.

**200** **Century Building, now Barnes & Noble Bookstore, 33 East 17th Street** (William Schickel, 1880–81), designated 1986. The red brick Century Building is a rare New York example of a Queen Anne-style commercial structure. Erected to house the prestigious Century Publishing Company, publisher of *The Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines, the building is characteristic of the finest Queen Anne design in its free use of classical motifs in stone and terra cotta and its employment of the style's trademark sunflowers. After standing vacant for many years, the building was converted into a bookstore, and the facade received an award-winning restoration.

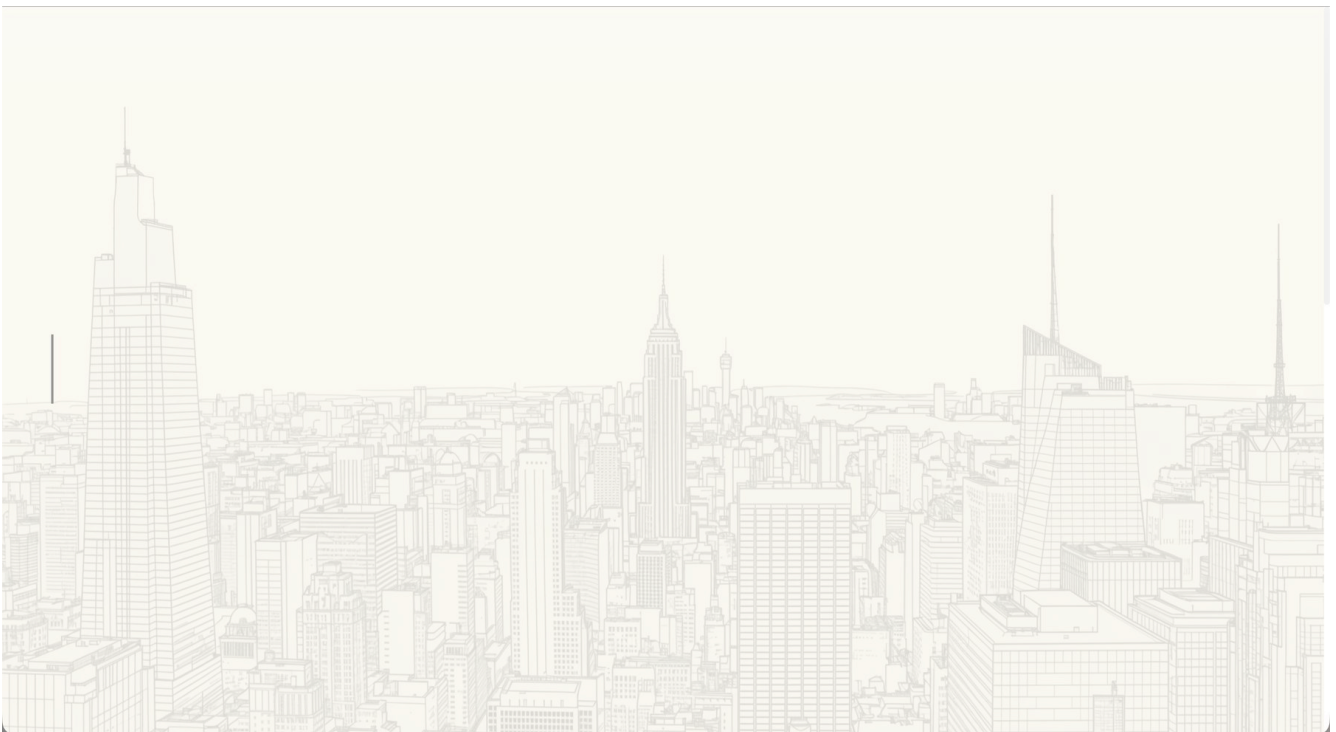
**201** **Everett Building, 200 Park Avenue South** (Goldwin Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), designated 1988. Located on the north side of Union Square, the Everett Building exemplifies an important development in the design of commercial high-rise buildings—the construction of functional, fireproof structures with large windows, open floor space, and simple classical detail. This emphasis on functionalism reflects the influence of Chicago skyscraper designs; in fact, the architect, Goldwin Starrett, had worked for four years in the Chicago office of Daniel Burnham.

**202** **Gorham Manufacturing Company Building, 809–891 Broadway** (Edward Hale Kendall, 1883–84; alteration, John H. Duncan, 1912), designated 1984. This commercial building in the Queen Anne style was erected for the Gorham Manufacturing Company, a leading American silver firm, for its retail outlet in the exclusive Ladies' Mile shopping district. The Gorham is an early example of a mixed-use building: only the lower two floors were occupied by the store; the upper floors were rented as bachelor apartments. By 1893, however, the building was entirely in commercial use. The architect John H. Duncan is responsible for a remodeling of the building in 1912 that entailed the removal of a corner tower and the addition of roof dormers. The building now contains shops at street level and apartments above.

**203** **Lord & Taylor Store, 901 Broadway** (James H. Giles, 1869–70), designated 1977. Two English immigrants, Samuel Lord and George Taylor, founded the dry goods firm

**LPC, *Union Square, 1890*, p. 1**

Quotes drawn from this page: 11 13 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32 33  
34 35 36 37 38 39 40 41 42 43 46 47 48 49 50 51 52 53



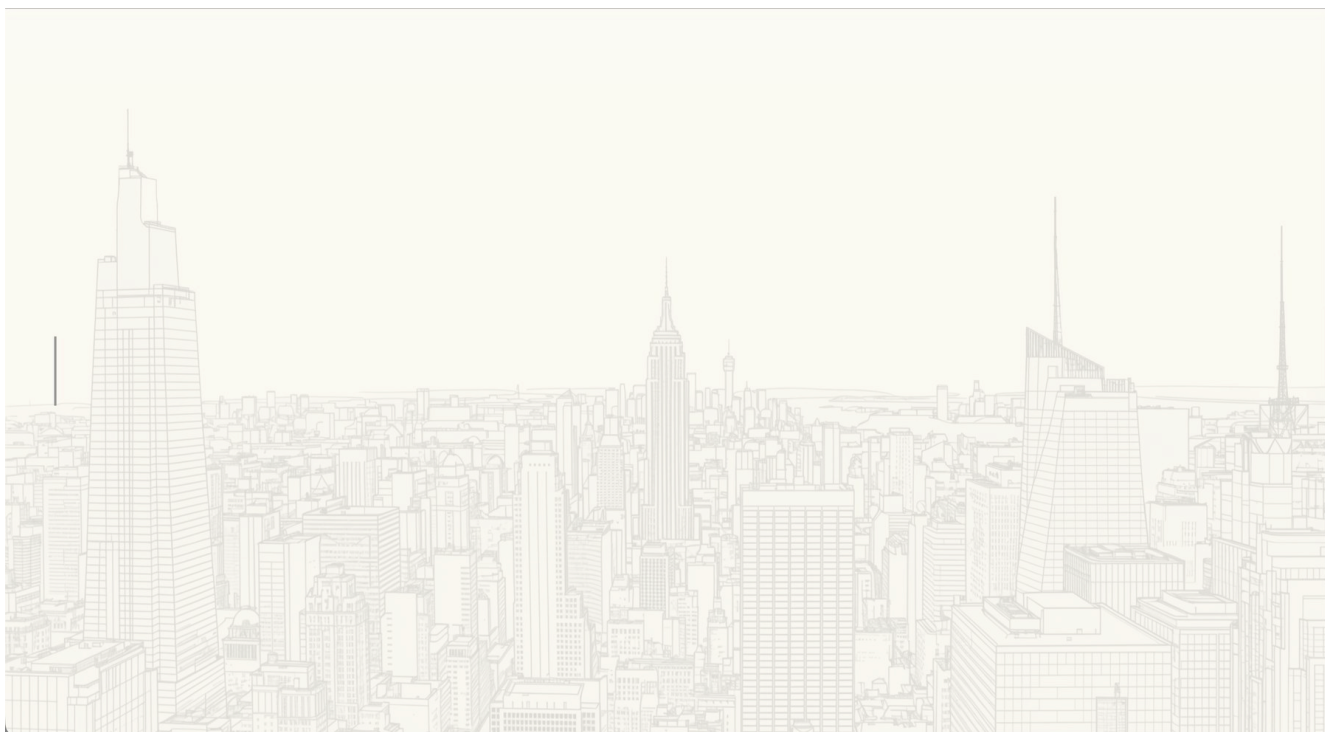
"<Architecture Style>\_Romanesque-Revival, <Base Color>\_Tumbleweed - 222 166 131, <Façade Color>\_Pearl White - 238 235 218, <Base Material>\_Indiana Limestone, Granite Bulkheads, <Façade Material>\_Indiana Limestone, Terra Cotta, Light Brick, <Entrance Description>\_4 Bays, Round Arch, Engaged Columns, Acanthus Scrolls, Norman Zigzag Molding, <Window Detail>\_Double Height Arcade, Arched, Byzantine Columns, Foliated Spandrels, Corbels, Limestone Voussoirs, Molded Enframements, <Brickwork Style>\_Smooth and Rock Faced Indiana Limestone, Layered Arcades, Griffin, Acanthus Scrolls, Byzantine Capitals, Human Heads, Lion Heads, Limestone Piers, Tripartite Typology, <Roofline Description>\_Projecting Cornice, Band of Bosses, Human/Lion Corbels, Byzantine Guilloche, Paired Spiral Columns, Dentils, Recessed Panels, Ovolo Molding, Acanthus Scroll Band."

mentioned as: 1-3 Union Square west

[View Document Image](#)

**AIA, *AIA Edition 3*, 1988, p. 186**

Quotes drawn from this page: 44





[W 3.] **American Savings Bank/originally Union Square Savings Bank**, 20 Union Sq. E., NE cor. E. 15th St. 1924. Henry Bacon.

A classy **Corinthian colonnade** is somewhat forlorn in these precincts. **Bacon's** best remembrance is the **Lincoln Memorial**.



[W 4a.] **Guardian Life Insurance Company/originally Germania Life Insurance Company**, 201 Park Ave. S., NE cor. E. 17th St. 1911. D'Oench & Yost. [W 4b.] **Annex**, 105 E. 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Irving Place. 1961. Skidmore, Owings & Merrill.

The **mansarded** bulk of this **Renaissance Revival** marvel is best seen from a distance, down 17th Street or from the adjacent Union Square Park. **Germania Life** was a name that became an onerous millstone at the advent of World War I. The board of directors agreed to rename it, picking a name with the largest number of reusable letters that they could find. **Guardian** still crowns the roof against its mansard backdrop.

Next door is the sleek annex, a simple grid of **aluminum and glass** infilled behind with white vertical blinds. As an accessory, it is a graceful annex to the proud parent, unabashedly "modern," an articulated annex.



[W 2.] Zeckendorf Towers (apts.)



[W 5.] Century Building at Union Sq.



[W 5.] Originally **The Century Building**, 33 E. 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Broadway to W. 18th St. 1881. William Schickel. ★

This red brick and whitestone charmer is where the popular Cen-

tury magazine (for grown-ups) and **St. Nicholas** (for boys and girls) were published before the century turned.

**[W 6.] 31 Union Square West/originally Bank of the Metropolis Building, NW cor. 16th St. 1903. Bruce Price.**

An early and unwitting **sliver building**, this neo-Renaissance slab now houses a restaurant in its original banking rooms, a place for **SUPERMAN'S** lunch.

**[W 7.] Originally Lincoln Building, 1 Union Sq. W., NW cor. E. 14th St. 1890. R. H. Robertson**

Romanesque Revival granite crowned with a cornice of **40** little windows with interstitial paired columns.

**[W 8.] Originally YWCA (Young Women's Christian Association)/formerly Rand School, 7 E. 15th St., bet. Union Sq. W. and Fifth Ave. ca. 1889. R. H. Robertson.**

Romanesque Revival in granite, brick, and brownstone. The grand bay windows give the entrance portal a stronger stature.



**[W 9a.] Sidney Hillman Health Center/originally Margaret Louisa Home, YWCA (lodging house), 16 E. 16th St., bet. Union Sq. W. and Fifth Ave. 1890. R. H. Robertson.**



of Liberty, Bartholdi offered the Lafayette statue as a token of French friendship with the American people in gratitude for their sympathy during the Franco-Prussian War. Lafayette, although an aristocrat, was sympathetic with the cause of the American Revolution and served as a Major General in the Continental Army. The pedestal is designed to resemble a ship's prow. 870.1

Facing Union Square between 14th and 15th streets is massive **Zeckendorf Towers** (Davis Brody & Assocs., William Zeckendorf, Jr., developer, 1987), a 670-unit condominium in four 29-story towers, topped by open framework pyramids. The towers are set on a seven-story base that fills a triangular plot while maintaining the orientation to the city street grid. Original plans called for much taller structures, but fierce community opposition forced the developer to scale them down, thus reducing the "darkening and overwhelming" effect on the park below and respecting Union Square's surroundings. The lower floors include retail establishments and also Beth Israel Medical Center facilities. At the very corner of the building at 14th Street was **Joe's Saloon**, rendered immortal by habitué Hugh A. D'Arcy, who, in 1887, penned the sentimental ballad *The Face on the Barroom Floor*.

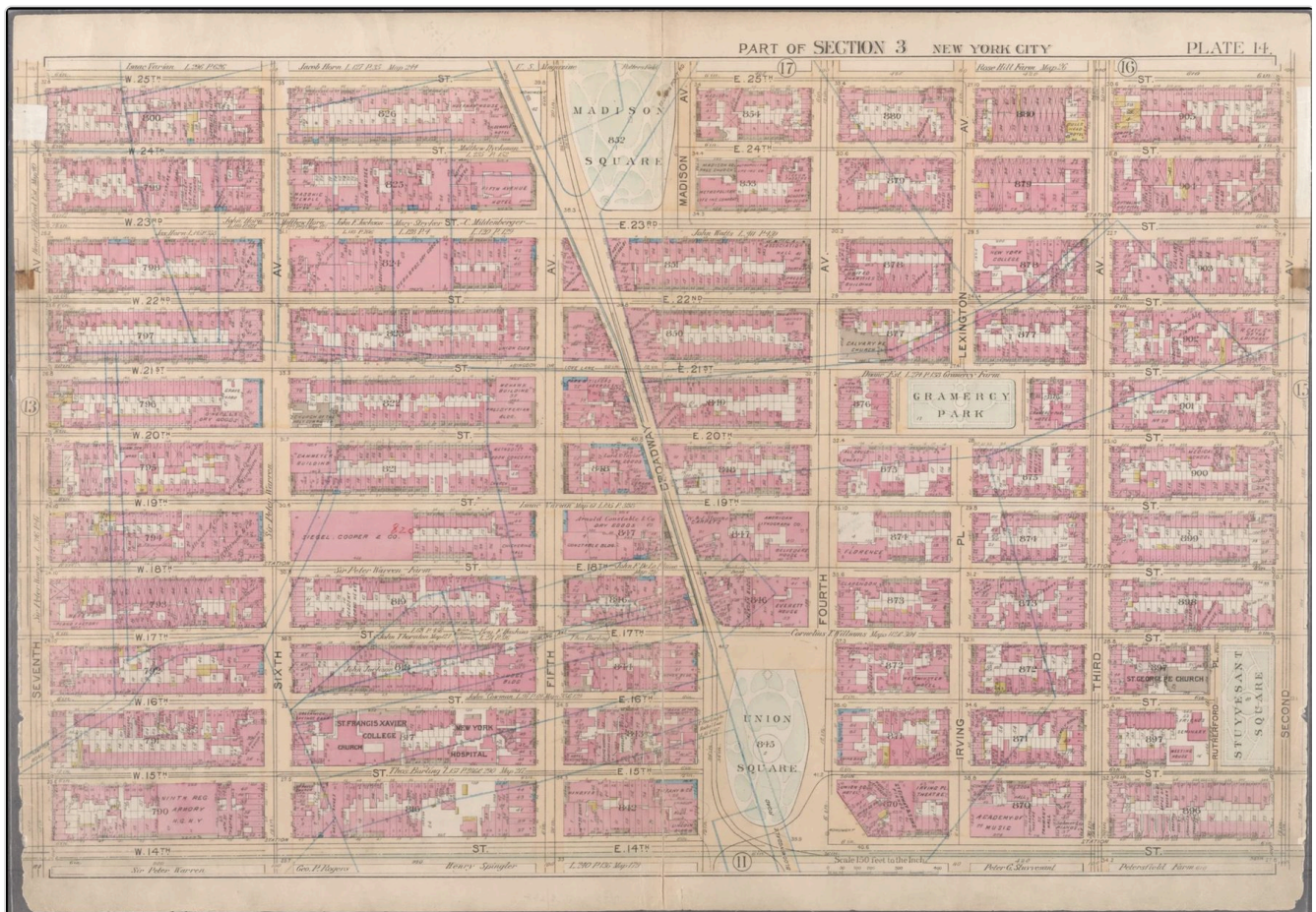
Turn right (west) on Union Square South, but stay on the park side. The building complex on the block between Fourth Avenue and Broadway comprises Circuit City, a Virgin Megastore, and a United Artists theater, plus residential apartments (Davis Brody Bond and Schuman Lichtenstein Claman & Efron, 1999). The 15 changing illuminated five-foot-high numerals display "the hours, minutes, seconds elapsed in the day; and the hours, minutes, and seconds remaining, symbolizing the city's speed, frenzy, and fragmentation." Intrinsic in the display is the astonishing multimedia sculpture of brick, concrete, steel, aluminum, gold leaf, incandescent light, steam, and sound called **Metronome** (Kristin Jones/Andrew Ginzel, 1999). A gift to New York, it is intended as a "celebration of the energy and vitality of the city." From the five-foot circle *Infinity*, steam emanates at noon and midnight, while from the 67-foot-long cone, a low tone is produced to synchronize with the plume of steam. Among other features are a five-foot rotating sphere of gold and black that mirrors the phases of the moon and *Relic*, an enlarged replica of the right hand of George Washington from the equestrian statue in the Park. Occupying the mid-block from 1870 to 1936 was the (old) **Union Square Theatre**, which survived as a converted retail store until it was demolished in 1990. 845.1

Dominating the Park entrance is the historic bronze **equestrian statue of George Washington** (Henry Kirke Brown with John Quincy Adams Ward, 1856; granite pedestal by Richard Upjohn). The statue represents Washington entering New York City on Evacuation Day, November 25, 1783, marking the end of British occupation during the Revolutionary War. The sculpture is based on an earlier Houdon bust and is considered one of the finest equestrian statues in America. It was moved from its original location at the intersection of Fourth Avenue early in the 20th century. [See engraving, page 227.]

Turn right at the Gandhi statue (described earlier) and walk north on Union Square West; note the recent attempt to re-create an “old-time” atmosphere by paving the street with Belgian blocks. At the corner of 14th Street, the **former Lincoln Building, No. 1 Union Square West** (R. H. Robertson, 1899), is a typical

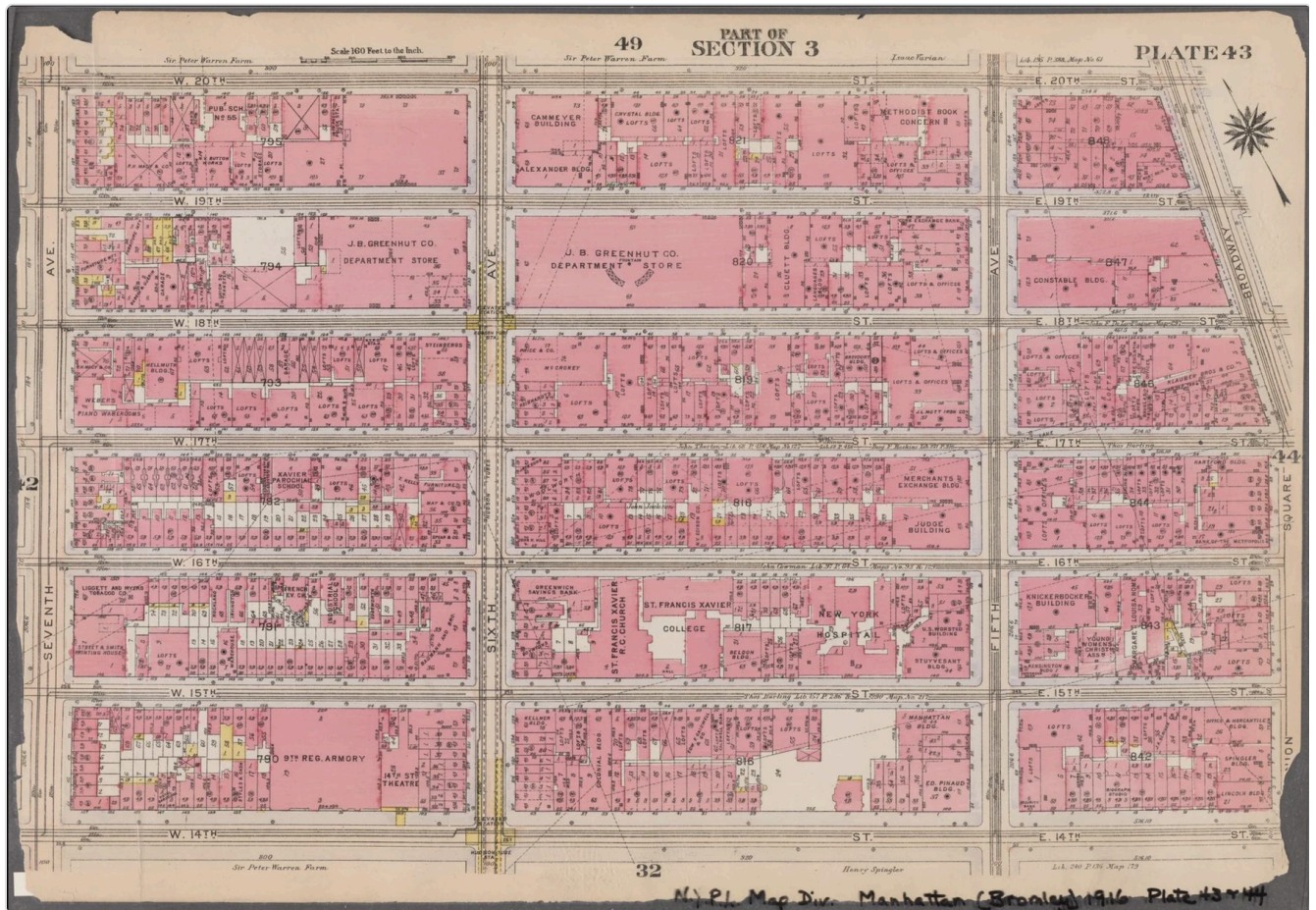
**Bromley, 1897 Bromleys Atlas, p. 19**

Quotes drawn from this page: 54



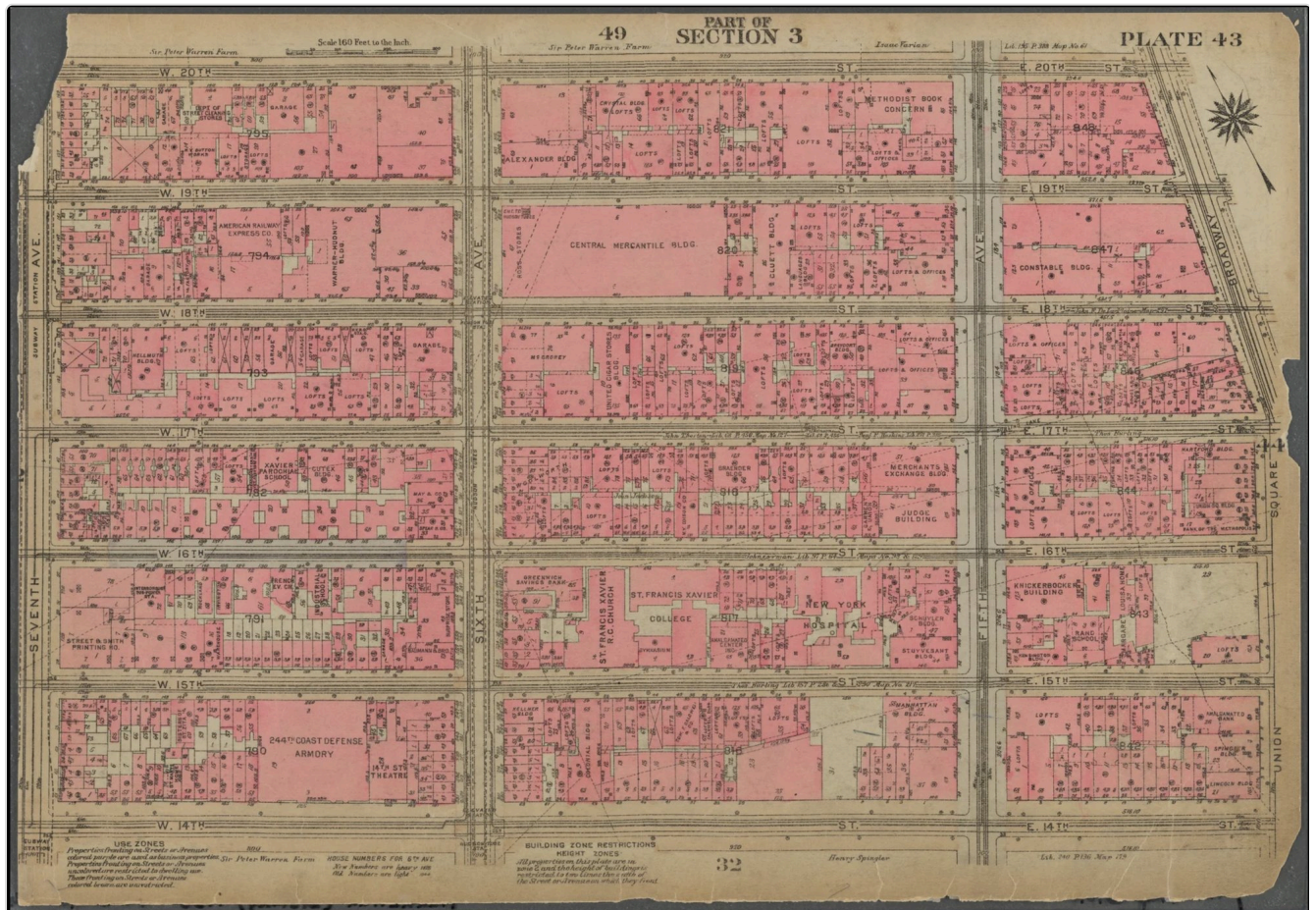
**G W Bromley & Co, 1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan, p. 54**

Quotes drawn from this page: 55



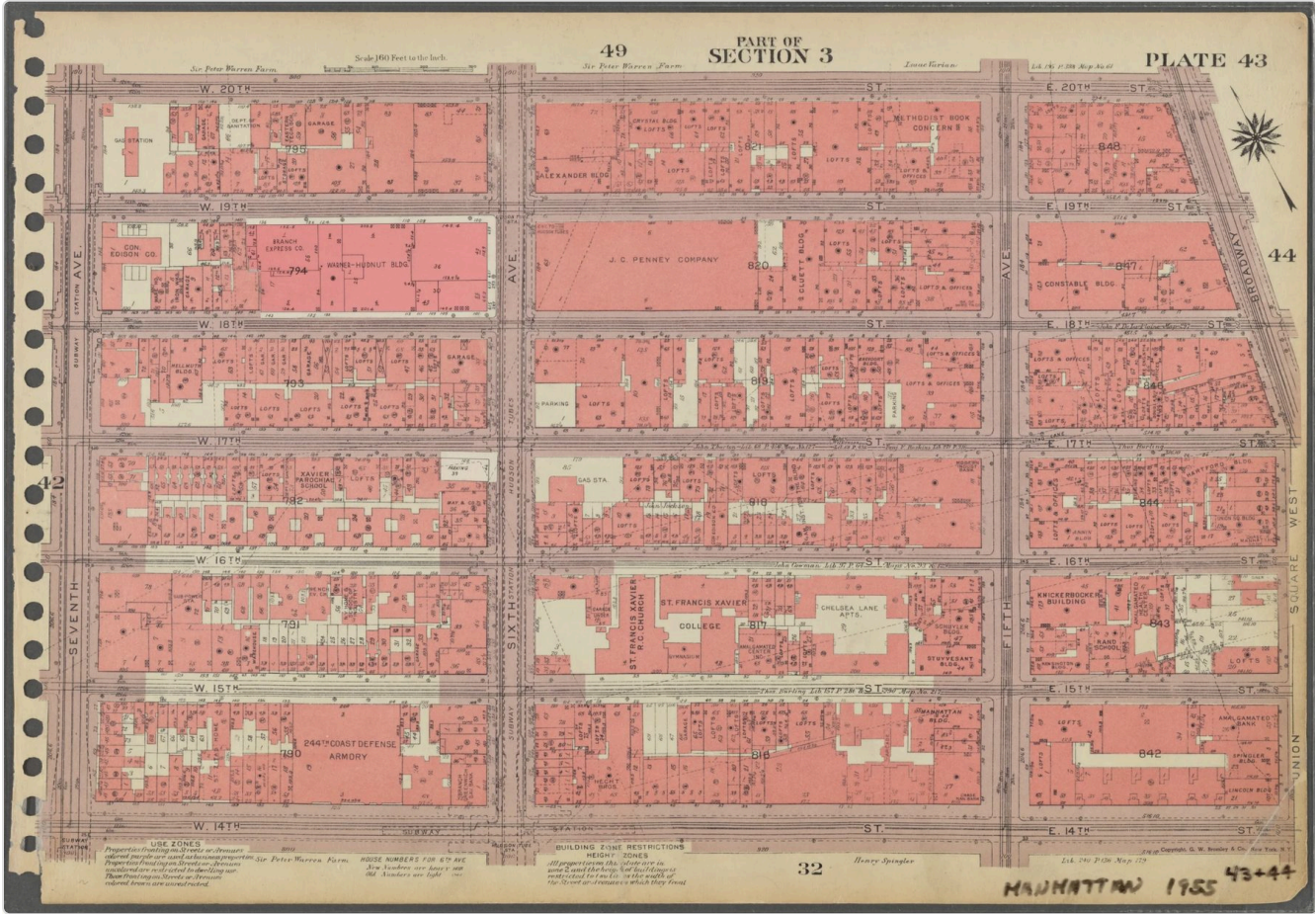
# Bromley, 1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan, p. 53

Quotes drawn from this page: 56



Bromley, 1955 Manhattan Land Book, p. 43

Quotes drawn from this page: 57



**Hennessy, *Walking Broadway*, 2020, p. 97**

Quotes drawn from this page: 59 60



Plant forms are abstracted and stylized under the influence of Moorish decoration to create this lush patterning. The central tower is an Islamic extravaganza and was once topped by a minaret.

From 1967 to 1973 the sixth floor of the Decker Building housed Andy Warhol's celebrated Factory. It was here in 1968 that the artist was shot by Valerie Solanas. Warhol subsequently relocated the Factory diagonally across the street to 860 Broadway.



97

## **E Bank of the Metropolis**

**31 Union Square West**

**844**

1903 · BRUCE PRICE

The familiar, sober classical vocabulary of bank architecture is enlivened here by a welcoming two-story bowed portico supported by a pair of gray granite Ionic columns facing Union Square. The long 16th Street elevation also features some distinctive touches. Notice the flattened arches floating in the openings of the ground level arcade and the lush foliate ornament in the panels under the windows higher up. A powerfully detailed balcony at the thirteenth story prepares the way for a bold copper cornice.

The block between 14th and 15th Streets offers two solid and accomplished historic structures: the **Spingler Building** **7** (5 Union Square West, 1897, W. H. Hume and Sons) and the **Lincoln Building** **6** (1 Union Square West, 1889, R. H. Robertson). The two facades share many compositional details, but one architect has chosen a classical vocabulary while the other has embraced the Romanesque.

**842**

More unusual is the contemporary building at 15 Union Square West. Behind the steel and glass are the arches of the cast iron facade from John Kellum's 1869 headquarters for **Tiffany & Company** **11**. The top seven floors were added to the original five when the building was converted to condominiums in 2009.

**842**



**Stern, *New York* 2000, 2006, p. 377**

Quotes drawn from this page: 61



a move that was rigorously opposed by the Union Square Community Coalition, a group largely made up of newer residents who had moved into lofts and apartments and feared the impact of real estate speculation on their rented homes. Efforts to rezone Zeckendorf's site coincided with a broader reassessment of the area's zoning, which had been studied in 1979–80 by Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates. Those recommendations formed the basis, in 1984, of the Department of City Planning's proposed special zoning district, intended to encourage mixed-use development on underutilized sites in the park's vicinity, especially Zeckendorf's proposed one-million-square-foot project.<sup>19</sup> Both the district and the Zeckendorf proposal for a twenty-six-story project were approved by the City Planning Commission in November 1984 and by the Board of Estimate in January 1985.<sup>20</sup> Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1–3 Union Square West; the Bank of the Metropolis (Bruce Price, 1903), 31 Union Square West; the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street; the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street; and the Germania Life Insurance Company Building (D'Oench & Yost, 1911), later the Guardian Life Building, 50 Union Square East.<sup>21</sup>

As built, the four twenty-story towers of Zeckendorf's project, unimaginatively titled Zeckendorf Towers, contained 670 condominium apartments rising above a seven-story base housing 320,000 square feet of offices, an atrium, a much-appreciated supermarket, theaters, and underground parking. Though banal in their detailed design, the scheme of slender, salmon-colored brick-clad towers, each topped by an open-work pyramidal crown—dismissed by the editors of the *AIA Guide* as “illuminated levitating . . . yarmulkes”—minimized shadows on the square and blockage of views from it to the tower of the Consolidated Gas Company Building (Warren & Wetmore, 1926), which they were intended to complement.<sup>22</sup> The office floors were entered from Fourth Avenue facing Union Square Park, while the apartments were entered off Fifteenth Street. In its bland uniformity and lock-step regularity, Zeckendorf Towers was hardly inspiring, but it did help the reemerging district turn the economic corner.

While most new construction in the area involved demolition of existing buildings, a through-block parcel that had been vacant since the early 1970s permitted the construction of the twelve-story Genesis Apartments (1995) for ninety-four homeless and low-income families at 113 East Thirteenth Street and an attendant 30,000-square-foot, two-story commercial building at 114 East Fourteenth Street.<sup>23</sup> The project was developed by Housing Enterprise for the Less Privileged (H.E.L.P.), a nonprofit organization founded by Andrew Cuomo, son of New York State Governor Mario Cuomo. As designed by Cooper, Robertson & Partners, the quietly contextual apartment building eschewed all outward signs of social engineering in favor of an expression that many would assume was intended for a much more affluent clientele. Additionally, the building's management program included a program-services staff of fifteen to help the homeless tenants, whose stay was limited to twelve months, make an adjustment back into mainstream society. Genesis provided playgrounds, a day-care center, a basketball court, a library, and a laundry room. Although many in the community were initially opposed to the project, it proved an excellent neighbor.

The retail building on Fourteenth Street, however, was not comparable in quality; its low height, a product of zoning restrictions, contributed to its suburban strip-mall character.

**1** Union Square South (1998), designed by Davis, Brody & Associates in association with Schuman, Lichtenstein, Claman & Efron, a twenty-seven-story, 180-unit apartment building atop an eighty-five-foot-high mixed-use retail base that included a fourteen-screen theater, occupied the highly visible 47,500-square-foot full-block site bounded by Fourth Avenue, Thirteenth Street, Broadway, and Fourteenth Street.<sup>24</sup> In 1995 the Related Companies had acquired the site from another developer who had cleared it of its buildings, including the historic Union Square Theater (1871; rebuilt, John Terhune and Leopold Eidlitz, 1889), 58 East Fourteenth Street, which had long been obscured behind a huge McDonald's sign.<sup>25</sup>

Responding to community concerns that this most prominent site might yield yet another business-as-usual apartment house banality, the developers entered into an agreement with the Municipal Art Society to select an architectural firm that would maximize the site's most important attributes, its axial relationship to the vista south along Park Avenue from Grand Central Terminal and its prominent location at the edge of Union Square Park. The society asked two dozen architects to name a firm, besides their own, that they would recommend for the job. From the responses, Related chose three firms to participate in a competition held in 1995: Davis, Brody & Associates, Robert A. M. Stern Architects, and Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates, which later withdrew. Stern proposed an eighteen-story tower on a five-story stone-clad site-filling retail base. The metal-trimmed brick-clad tower was to be set back from the property line to create a strong south terminus for Park Avenue, recalling the campanile-like configuration of Warren & Wetmore's New York Central Building (1929), which, until the construction of the Pan Am Building in 1963, had concluded the axis of Park Avenue on the north side of Grand Central.

Davis, Brody's winning scheme, designed by Steven Davis, son of founding partner Lewis Davis, sought to merge the base with the tower. The initial rendering revealed stylish asymmetrical patterns of windows as well as a deep balcony cut into the north wall. But as built, its blocky mass was pretty banal, the cut reduced to virtual inconsequence, leaving the heavy aesthetic lifting to the work of the artists Kristin Jones and Andrew Ginzel. In a separate competition organized by the Public Art Fund, the two had been chosen to embellish a 100-by-60-foot wall on the building's north facade, between the commercial base and the tower. Jones and Ginzel proposed *Metronome*, confronting the street with a brick wall overlaid with an undulating wavelike pattern of concentric circles and a so-called eye, a four-foot-in-diameter opening that emitted clouds of steam, clearly upstaging the rather tepid facade of the host building. The steam, intended by the artists to recall the geothermal outpouring of Old Faithful, poured forward twice a day, at noon and at midnight, as part of the artists' intention to examine time itself. Each emission was enhanced by the sounding of a long, tapered horn intended to echo the passage of time. A digital clock on the left side of the wall augmented the frequent movements of the city by simultaneously counting and subtracting the hours of the day, with the converging digits in the middle absorbed by a blur of activity, intended to suggest the present.

